

Single Responsibility Principle (SRP)

The **Single Responsibility Principle (SRP)** is the first principle of the **SOLID** design principles.

At a high level:

A software component should have one clear responsibility and one primary reason to change.

SRP is often misunderstood as:

"A class should have only one method."

That is **not** what SRP means.

A class can have many methods and still follow SRP as long as those methods belong to the same responsibility.

The real question is:

Does this component have one cohesive responsibility, or does it contain multiple unrelated reasons to change?

This README explains:

- Why SRP was needed
- What problem it solves
- What happens when SRP is violated
- How to identify responsibilities
- How to refactor code using SRP
- TypeScript examples
- Go examples
- Real-world backend use cases
- Common mistakes and over-engineering
- How SRP connects with the other SOLID principles

1. Introduction

What is SRP?

The Single Responsibility Principle states:

A class, module, function, or component should have one responsibility and therefore one primary reason to change.

The important part is:

One primary reason to change

Consider this:

```
UserService
|
+-- Validate user
+-- Hash password
+-- Save user to database
+-- Send welcome email
+-- Generate PDF
```

At first, putting everything inside `UserService` might seem convenient.

But now imagine the following changes:

```
Database technology changes
↓
UserService changes

Email provider changes
↓
UserService changes

PDF format changes
↓
UserService changes

Password hashing requirements change
↓
UserService changes
```

The same class has multiple independent reasons to change.

That is the problem SRP tries to solve.

A better design could be:

```
UserService
↓
Coordinates user registration

UserValidator
↓
Validates user data
```

```
PasswordHasher
  ↓
Hashes passwords

UserRepository
  ↓
Persists users

EmailService
  ↓
Sends emails

PdfService
  ↓
Generates PDFs
```

Now each component has a clearer responsibility.

2. Why Was SRP Needed?

When applications are small, developers often put several related operations inside one class.

For example:

```
class UserService {
    createUser() {}
}
```

Then requirements are added:

```
class UserService {
    createUser() {}
    validateUser() {}
    hashPassword() {}
    saveUser() {}
    sendEmail() {}
    generateReport() {}
}
```

Eventually:

```
class UserService {
    createUser() {}
    updateUser() {}
    deleteUser() {}
}
```

```

    validateUser() {}
    hashPassword() {}
    saveUser() {}
    sendEmail() {}
    resetPassword() {}
    generateInvoice() {}
    uploadProfilePicture() {}
    logActivity() {}
}

```

The class slowly becomes responsible for everything.

This usually happens because developers think:

"All of these things are related to users, so they should be inside `UserService`."

But being related to the same entity does **not** necessarily mean they belong to the same responsibility.

A user can be:

```

User data
Authentication
Persistence
Notifications
Payments
Reports
Files
Analytics

```

These are different concerns even though they all involve a user.

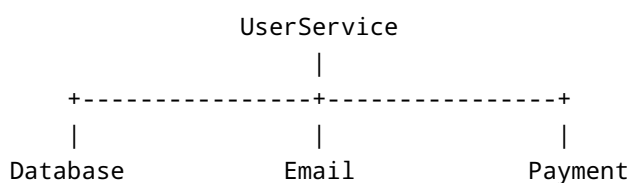
3. The Problem

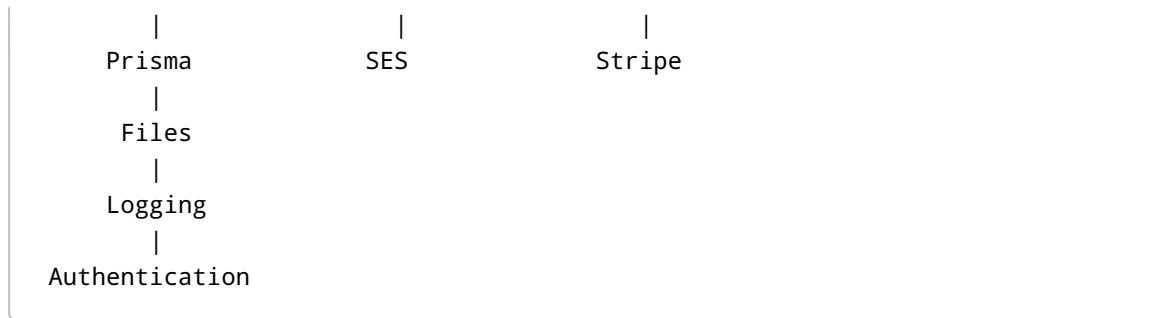
When a component accumulates too many responsibilities, several problems appear.

3.1 God Objects

A **God Object** is a class that knows too much and does too much.

For example:





The class becomes the center of many unrelated parts of the system.

The bigger it becomes, the more dangerous changes become.

4. Tight Coupling

A class with many responsibilities usually has many dependencies.

For example:

```
import bcrypt from "bcrypt";
import Stripe from "stripe";
import nodemailer from "nodemailer";
import PDFDocument from "pdfkit";
import { PrismaClient } from "@prisma/client";
```

Now `UserService` knows about:

- Password hashing
- Payments
- Email
- PDF generation
- Database persistence

Suppose you replace:

SendGrid

with:

AWS SES

The user service must change.

Suppose you replace:

Prisma

with:

MongoDB

The user service must change again.

The class is now tightly coupled to infrastructure.

5. Testing Nightmares

Imagine:

```
class UserService {  
  async registerUser() {  
    // validate  
    // hash password  
    // database  
    // email  
    // Kafka  
    // PDF  
  }  
}
```

To test the registration flow, you might need:

Database
Email provider
Kafka
PDF generator
Password hashing
Configuration
Environment variables

A simple unit test becomes difficult because one method is responsible for many external systems.

With SRP:

```
UserValidator  
  ↓  
Test validation independently
```

```
PasswordHasher
  ↓
Test password hashing independently

UserRepository
  ↓
Test persistence independently

EmailService
  ↓
Test email independently
```

The tests become smaller and more focused.

6. Difficult Changes

Imagine the email provider changes.

Without SRP:

```
Email provider changes
  ↓
Large UserService changes
  ↓
Many unrelated dependencies
  ↓
Large regression-testing surface
```

With SRP:

```
Email provider changes
  ↓
EmailService changes
```

The change is isolated.

This is sometimes called reducing the **blast radius** of a change.

7. Difficult to Understand

Imagine opening a 2,000-line service.

You want to understand how user registration works, but the same class contains:

```
Authentication
Payments
Email
Database
File uploads
Analytics
PDF generation
Logging
```

You now have to understand unrelated code before changing a small feature.

SRP encourages components with clear boundaries:

```
UserService
UserRepository
EmailService
PasswordHasher
UserValidator
```

The code becomes easier to navigate.

8. The Solution

SRP encourages us to separate responsibilities according to their **reason for change**.

Instead of:

```
UserService
|
+-- Validation
+-- Hashing
+-- Database
+-- Email
+-- PDF generation
```

we create:

```
UserService
|
+-- UserValidator
+-- PasswordHasher
+-- UserRepository
```



```
+-- EmailService
+-- PdfService
```

The `UserService` can still coordinate the complete workflow.

The difference is that it no longer owns the implementation of every concern.

9. What SRP Improves

Maintainability

Changes are more localized.

```
Change database
  ↓
UserRepository

Change email provider
  ↓
EmailService

Change password hashing
  ↓
PasswordHasher
```

Testability

Each component can be tested independently.

For example:

```
PasswordHasher
  ↓
Test password hashing

UserRepository
  ↓
Test persistence

EmailService
  ↓
Test email behavior
```

The tests no longer need every dependency at once.

Readability

Compare:

```
UserService
  1500 lines
```

with:

```
UserService
UserRepository
EmailService
PasswordHasher
UserValidator
```

The second design communicates intent more clearly.

Lower Coupling

Instead of:

```
Large Service
|
+-- Database
+-- Email
+-- Payment
+-- File system
+-- PDF
```

you move toward:

```
UserService
|
+-- UserRepository
+-- EmailService
```

The service has fewer direct responsibilities.

10. Important Clarification: One Responsibility ≠ One Method

This is one of the most important points about SRP.

This is perfectly reasonable:

```
class UserRepository {  
    create() {}  
  
    findById() {}  
  
    findByEmail() {}  
  
    update() {}  
  
    delete() {}  
}
```

There are several methods.

But all methods share one responsibility:

Persisting users.

Therefore, the class can still follow SRP.

Do not think:

```
One method  
  ↓  
One class
```

Think:

```
One cohesive responsibility  
  ↓  
One primary reason to change
```

11. Implementation Guide

The easiest way to apply SRP is to follow a step-by-step reasoning process.

Step 1: Understand What the Component Does

Take a large class and list everything it currently does.

Example:

```
UserService  
  
- Validate email  
- Hash password  
- Save user  
- Send email  
- Generate PDF  
- Log activity
```

Don't immediately start moving code.

First understand the existing responsibilities.

Step 2: Group Related Behavior

Group operations that belong to the same concern.

```
Validation  
  └─ Validate user  
  
Security  
  └─ Hash password  
  
Persistence  
  └─ Save user  
  
Notification  
  └─ Send email  
  
Reporting  
  └─ Generate PDF  
  
Observability  
  └─ Log activity
```

This reveals natural responsibility boundaries.

Step 3: Ask "What Would Cause This to Change?"

This is one of the best SRP questions.

For example:

```
Database requirements change
    ↓
Persistence logic changes

Email provider changes
    ↓
Email logic changes

Security requirements change
    ↓
Password hashing changes
```

If all these changes affect one class, the class probably has multiple responsibilities.

Step 4: Extract Independent Responsibilities

Create components around meaningful boundaries.

For example:

```
UserService
|
+-- UserValidator
+-- PasswordHasher
+-- UserRepository
+-- EmailService
```

Step 5: Keep the Main Workflow Simple

After extraction, the main service should coordinate the use case.

For example:

```
class UserService {
    async registerUser() {
        validate();
        hashPassword();
        saveUser();
    }
}
```

```
        sendEmail();
    }
}
```

This is not automatically a violation.

If the responsibility of the service is:

Coordinate the user registration use case

then calling multiple focused components is completely reasonable.

Step 6: Avoid Over-Engineering

Do not create a separate class for every small line of code.

Bad:

```
EmailValidationService
EmailValidationFactory
EmailValidationManager
EmailValidationProvider
EmailValidationStrategy
```

for:

```
email.includes("@")
```

SRP is about clear boundaries, not maximum fragmentation.

12. TypeScript Example

Before — Violating SRP

Consider a user registration service:

```
import bcrypt from "bcrypt";

class UserService {
    async registerUser(
        name: string,
        email: string,
        password: string
```

```

    ) {
      // Validation
      if (!email.includes("@")) {
        throw new Error("Invalid email");
      }

      // Password hashing
      const hashedPassword =
        await bcrypt.hash(password, 10);

      // Database logic
      const user = await db.user.create({
        data: {
          name,
          email,
          password: hashedPassword
        }
      });

      // Email notification
      await sendEmail({
        to: email,
        subject: "Welcome",
        body: "Welcome to our application"
      });

      return user;
    }
  }
}

```

The class performs:

```

UserService
|
+-- Validation
+-- Password hashing
+-- Database persistence
+-- Email notification

```

There are multiple reasons for this class to change.

13. TypeScript — After SRP

UserValidator

```
class UserValidator {  
  validateEmail(email: string): void {  
    if (!email.includes("@")) {  
      throw new Error("Invalid email");  
    }  
  }  
}
```

Its responsibility is:

Validate user input

PasswordHasher

```
import bcrypt from "bcrypt";  
  
class PasswordHasher {  
  async hash(password: string): Promise<string> {  
    return bcrypt.hash(password, 10);  
  }  
}
```

Its responsibility is:

Password hashing

UserRepository

```
interface User {  
  id: string;  
  name: string;  
  email: string;  
  password: string;  
}  
  
interface CreateUserInput {  
  name: string;
```



```

    email: string;
    password: string;
}

class UserRepository {
  async create(
    data: CreateUserInput
  ): Promise<User> {
    return db.user.create({
      data
    });
  }
}

```

Its responsibility is:

User persistence

EmailService

```

class EmailService {
  async sendWelcomeEmail(
    email: string
  ): Promise<void> {
    await sendEmail({
      to: email,
      subject: "Welcome",
      body: "Welcome to our application"
    });
  }
}

```

Its responsibility is:

Sending email

UserService

Now the main service coordinates the workflow:

```

class UserService {
  constructor(
    private readonly validator: UserValidator,

```

```

    private readonly passwordHasher: PasswordHasher,
    private readonly userRepository: UserRepository,
    private readonly emailService: EmailService
  ) {}

  async registerUser(
    name: string,
    email: string,
    password: string
  ) {
    this.validator.validateEmail(email);

    const hashedPassword =
      await this.passwordHasher.hash(password);

    const user =
      await this.userRepository.create({
        name,
        email,
        password: hashedPassword
      });

    await this.emailService.sendWelcomeEmail(
      email
    );

    return user;
  }
}

```

The responsibility of `UserService` is now:

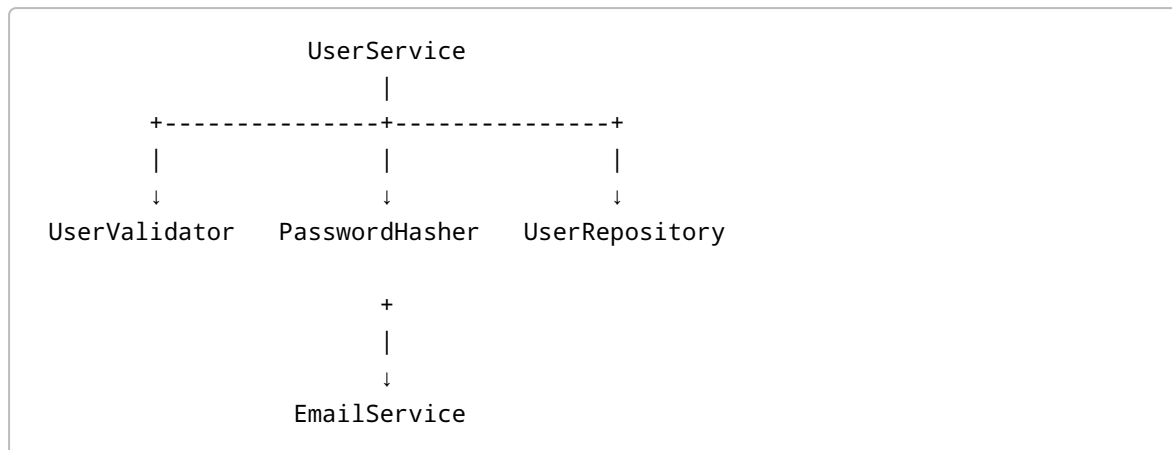
Coordinate user registration

It does not implement:

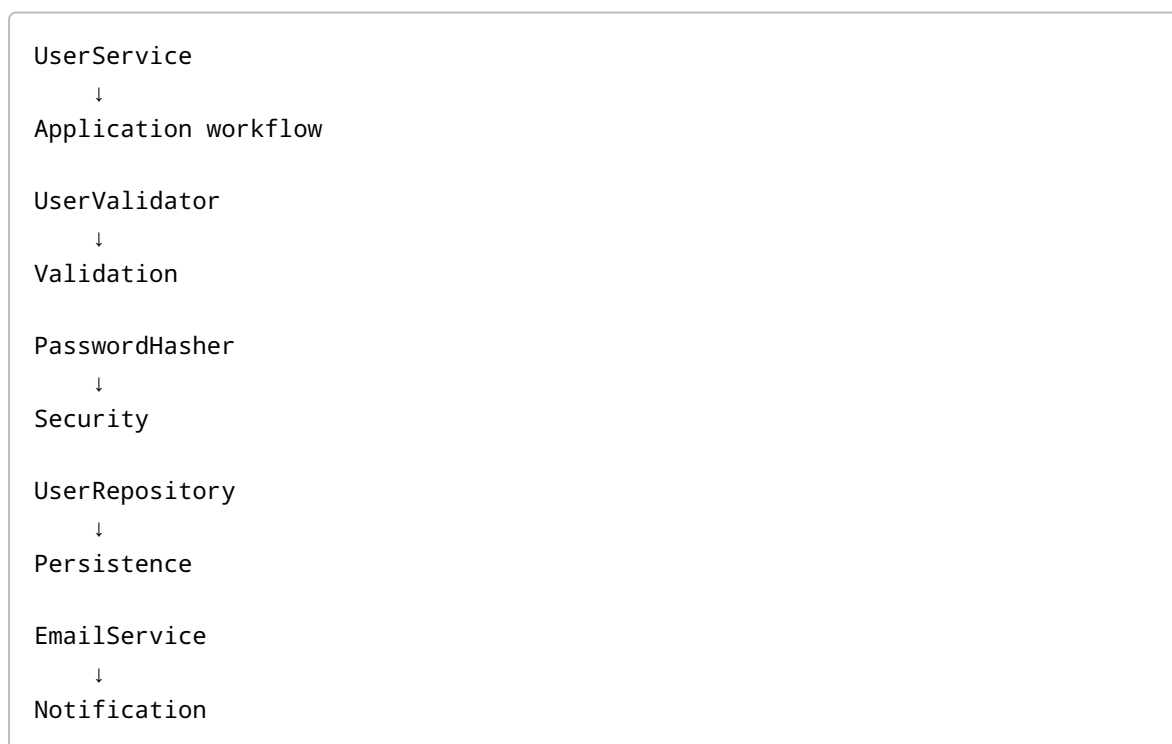
How validation works
 How password hashing works
 How persistence works
 How email delivery works

14. TypeScript — Architecture

The final structure looks like:



Or conceptually:



15. TypeScript — Benefits of the Refactoring

Suppose the application moves from:

bcrypt

to:

argon2

Only:

PasswordHasher

needs to change.

Suppose:

PostgreSQL + Prisma

is replaced by:

MongoDB

The persistence implementation changes.

Suppose:

SendGrid

is replaced by:

AWS SES

The email implementation changes.

The registration workflow does not need to be rewritten.

This is the practical value of SRP.

16. Go Example

We can apply the same principle in Go.

Suppose we have an order-processing system.

The processor performs:

- price calculation,
 - persistence,
 - logging.
-

17. Go — Before SRP

```
package order

import (
    "database/sql"
    "log"
)

type Order struct {
    ID        string
    Quantity  int
    Price     float64
}

type OrderProcessor struct {
    DB *sql.DB
}

func (p *OrderProcessor) ProcessOrder(
    order Order,
) error {

    // Calculate total
    total := float64(order.Quantity) * order.Price

    // Save order
    _, err := p.DB.Exec(
        "INSERT INTO orders (id, total) VALUES ($1, $2)",
        order.ID,
        total,
    )

    if err != nil {
        return err
    }

    // Logging
    log.Printf(
        "Order %s processed with total %.2f",
        order.ID,
        total,
    )

    return nil
}
```

The processor owns three concerns:

```
OrderProcessor
|
+-- Calculation
+-- Database persistence
+-- Logging
```

18. Go — After SRP

Calculator

```
package order

type Calculator struct{}

func (Calculator) CalculateTotal(
    quantity int,
    price float64,
) float64 {
    return float64(quantity) * price
}
```

Responsibility:

```
Calculate order totals
```

Repository

Define an interface:

```
package order

type Repository interface {
    Save(order Order) error
}
```

Its responsibility is:

```
Persist orders
```

A PostgreSQL implementation:

```

package order

import "database/sql"

type PostgresRepository struct {
    DB *sql.DB
}

func (r *PostgresRepository) Save(
    order Order,
) error {

    _, err := r.DB.Exec(
        "INSERT INTO orders (id, total) VALUES ($1, $2)",
        order.ID,
        order.Total,
    )

    return err
}

```

Logger

Define a focused interface:

```

package order

type Logger interface {
    Info(message string)
}

```

Implementation:

```

package order

import "log"

type StandardLogger struct{}

func (StandardLogger) Info(
    message string,
) {
    log.Println(message)
}

```

19. Go — OrderProcessor After SRP

```
package order

import "fmt"

type OrderProcessor struct {
    calculator Calculator
    repository Repository
    logger      Logger
}

func NewOrderProcessor(
    calculator Calculator,
    repository Repository,
    logger Logger,
) *OrderProcessor {

    return &OrderProcessor{
        calculator: calculator,
        repository: repository,
        logger:     logger,
    }
}

func (p *OrderProcessor) ProcessOrder(
    order Order,
) error {

    order.Total =
        p.calculator.CalculateTotal(
            order.Quantity,
            order.Price,
        )

    if err := p.repository.Save(order); err != nil {
        return err
    }

    p.logger.Info(
        fmt.Sprintf(
            "Order %s processed with total %.2f",
            order.ID,
            order.Total,
        ),
    )

    return nil
}
```


Now:

```
OrderProcessor
|
+-- Calculator
|
+-- Repository
|
+-- Logger
```

The processor is responsible for:

Coordinating the order-processing workflow.

20. Go — Why Interfaces Are Useful

Because the processor depends on interfaces:

```
type Repository interface {
    Save(order Order) error
}
```

we can have multiple implementations:

```
Repository
|
+-- PostgresRepository
+-- MongoRepository
+-- InMemoryRepository
+-- MockRepository
```

The `OrderProcessor` does not care which persistence technology is used.

This is especially useful for testing.

21. Go — Testing with a Mock

We can create a simple mock:

```
type MockRepository struct {
    SavedOrder Order
}
```

```
func (m *MockRepository) Save(
    order Order,
) error {

    m.SavedOrder = order

    return nil
}
```

Now the processor can be tested without a real PostgreSQL database.

The test can focus on:

```
Did OrderProcessor calculate the correct total?

Did OrderProcessor call the repository?

Did OrderProcessor log the result?
```

The database implementation does not need to exist during the unit test.

22. Before vs After

TypeScript

Before

```
UserService
|
+-- Validation
+-- Password hashing
+-- Database
+-- Email
```

After

```
UserService
|
+-- UserValidator
+-- PasswordHasher
+-- UserRepository
+-- EmailService
```

Go

Before

```
OrderProcessor
|
+-- Calculation
+-- Database
+-- Logging
```

After

```
OrderProcessor
|
+-- Calculator
+-- Repository
+-- Logger
```

The important improvement is not the number of classes or files.

The important improvement is:

```
Different responsibilities
      ↓
Clear ownership
      ↓
Independent changes
      ↓
Lower coupling
```

23. Real-World Use Cases

SRP becomes particularly useful in backend systems where multiple concerns exist.

Common examples include:

```
HTTP
Business logic
Database
Caching
Authentication
Authorization
Payments
Email
```

```
File storage
Messaging
Logging
External APIs
```

23.1 E-Commerce Checkout

Checkout may involve:

```
Cart validation
Pricing
Coupons
Inventory
Order creation
Payment
Email
Events
Invoices
```

Instead of one giant service:

```
CheckoutService
```

you may have:

```
CheckoutService
|
+-- CartValidator
+-- PricingService
+-- InventoryService
+-- PaymentService
+-- OrderRepository
+-- NotificationService
```

`CheckoutService` coordinates the checkout use case.

The individual components own their specific concerns.

24. Hotel Booking System

A booking system may involve:

```
Availability checking
Room locking
Price calculation
Booking creation
Payment
Notifications
Events
```

A reasonable design could be:

```
BookingService
|
+-- AvailabilityService
+-- RoomLockService
+-- PricingService
+-- BookingRepository
+-- PaymentService
+-- NotificationService
```

This becomes especially useful when dealing with:

- database transactions,
- concurrent bookings,
- row locking,
- distributed systems,
- payment providers,
- asynchronous events.

25. Payment Systems

A payment system could involve multiple providers:

```
PaymentService
  |
  ↓
PaymentProvider
  /
 /
Stripe   Razorpay
```

Each provider handles its own integration details.

The application service does not need to know every API detail.

26. File Storage Systems

A file-storage application may include:

```
File validation
S3 upload
Metadata persistence
Virus scanning
Quota calculation
Notifications
```

These concerns can be separated:

```
StorageService
|
+-- FileValidator
+-- ObjectStorage
+-- FileRepository
+-- QuotaService
+-- NotificationService
```

27. When Should You Use SRP?

SRP is particularly valuable when:

- A class is becoming very large.
- Unrelated requirements frequently modify the same class.
- Unit tests are difficult to write.
- The class depends on many unrelated technologies.
- Business logic is mixed with infrastructure logic.
- A change has a large blast radius.
- Different teams frequently modify the same component.
- Several different reasons can cause the component to change.

One strong signal is:

"Every new feature keeps adding another unrelated method to the same class."

That is usually worth investigating.

28. Common Pitfalls

SRP is useful, but it can also be overused.

28.1 One Method = One Class

This is a common mistake:

```
CreateUserService  
GetUserService  
UpdateUserService  
DeleteUserService
```

For a small application, this can create unnecessary complexity.

A simpler design might be:

```
UserService  
|  
+-- create()  
+-- get()  
+-- update()  
+-- delete()
```

These operations can reasonably belong to the same user-management responsibility.

28.2 Too Many Interfaces

Do not create interfaces simply because you want to "follow SOLID."

Interfaces are especially useful when you have:

```
Multiple implementations  
Replaceable infrastructure  
External providers  
Testing requirements
```

An abstraction should solve a real design problem.

28.3 Splitting Code Without Understanding It

Do not take:

```
UserService  
    1000 lines
```

and mechanically turn it into:

```
UserService1
UserService2
UserService3
UserService4
```

The number of files decreased, but the architecture may not have improved.

The responsibilities need to be understood first.

28.4 Creating Abstractions Too Early

Avoid designing:

```
EmailValidationFactory
EmailValidationProvider
EmailValidationManager
EmailValidationStrategy
```

for simple validation logic.

For example:

```
function isValidEmail(email: string): boolean {
    return email.includes("@");
}
```

may be all you need.

Start simple.

Introduce abstractions when the system actually needs them.

29. SRP and Cohesion

A useful concept for understanding SRP is **cohesion**.

Cohesion asks:

How closely related are the responsibilities inside a component?

High cohesion:


```
class UserRepository {  
    create() {}  
  
    findById() {}  
  
    findByEmail() {}  
  
    update() {}  
  
    delete() {}  
}
```

All methods relate to:

User persistence

Low cohesion:

```
class UserService {  
    createUser() {}  
  
    sendEmail() {}  
  
    generatePDF() {}  
  
    processPayment() {}  
  
    uploadFile() {}  
}
```

These operations belong to different concerns.

A healthy design generally aims for:

High Cohesion
+
Low Coupling

SRP helps achieve that.

30. SRP and the Other SOLID Principles

SRP is the first SOLID principle:

```
S → Single Responsibility Principle
O → Open/Closed Principle
L → Liskov Substitution Principle
I → Interface Segregation Principle
D → Dependency Inversion Principle
```

These principles are related.

For example:

SRP

Separates responsibilities:

```
UserService
UserRepository
EmailService
```

Dependency Inversion

Allows us to depend on abstractions:

```
interface UserRepository {
  create(): Promise<User>;
}
```

Open/Closed Principle

Makes it easier to add implementations without constantly changing existing code:

```
PaymentProvider
|
+-- StripeProvider
+-- RazorpayProvider
```

Interface Segregation

Encourages focused interfaces:

```
Logger
|
+-- info()

Repository
```

```
|  
+-- save()
```

Good application architecture often emerges when these principles work together.

31. Practical SRP Decision Process

Whenever you see a large component, ask these questions:

1. What does this component do?
↓
2. What responsibilities does it contain?
↓
3. Which responsibilities are related?
↓
4. Which responsibilities can change independently?
↓
5. Who would request those changes?
↓
6. Can those responsibilities have clearer ownership?
↓
7. Would extracting them actually improve the design?
↓
8. Am I separating code for a real reason,
or simply creating more classes?

This approach is more useful than blindly following a rule.

32. SRP Checklist

Use this during code review:

- [] Can I clearly describe this component's responsibility?
- [] Does it contain unrelated behavior?
- [] Could unrelated requirements cause it to change?
- [] Does it depend on many unrelated technologies?
- [] Is it difficult to unit test?
- [] Is business logic mixed with infrastructure logic?
- [] Can one responsibility change without touching another?
- [] Would extracting a responsibility make the code clearer?
- [] Am I avoiding unnecessary fragmentation?
- [] Is the abstraction solving an actual problem?

33. Final Mental Model

Do not remember SRP as:

```
One class
  ↓
One method
```

Remember it as:

```
One cohesive responsibility
  ↓
One primary reason to change
  ↓
Clear ownership
  ↓
Lower coupling
  ↓
Easier testing
  ↓
Easier maintenance
```

The best question to ask is:

"What different kinds of changes could force this component to change?"

For example:

```
Database changes
Email changes
Payment changes
Security changes
Reporting changes
```

If all of them modify the same class, that class probably has too many responsibilities.

But if the answer is:

```
Changes to the user-registration workflow
```

then the responsibility is much more focused.

34. Conclusion

The **Single Responsibility Principle** is fundamentally about creating **clear responsibility boundaries**.

It does not mean:

- every class must be tiny,
- every method needs its own class,
- every class needs an interface,
- every file must contain only a few lines.

Instead, SRP asks us to design components so that:

```
Related behavior
    ↓
Lives together

Unrelated behavior
    ↓
Lives separately
```

A good SRP-based design generally gives us:

```
Clear responsibilities
    ↓
High cohesion
    ↓
Lower coupling
```

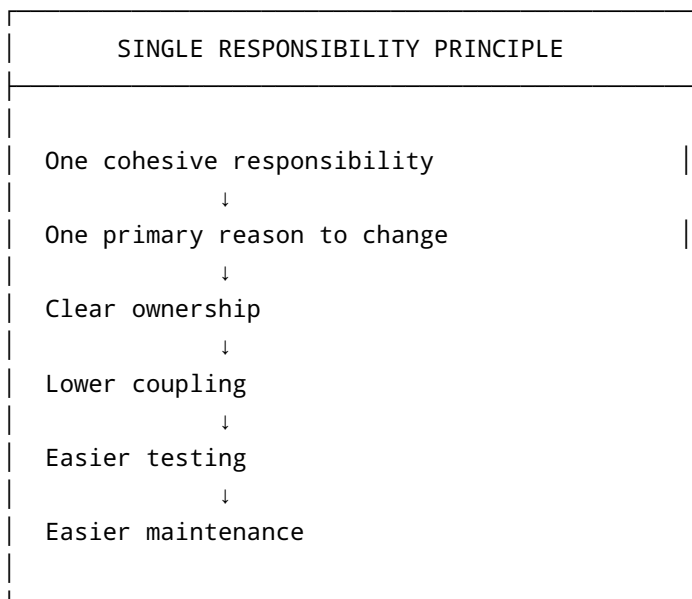
↓
Smaller changes
↓
Simpler tests
↓
Better maintainability
↓
Easier long-term evolution

The most important lesson is:

SRP is not about making classes small. It is about making their responsibilities clear.

When a component has one cohesive responsibility and one primary reason to change, the code becomes easier to understand, test, modify, and maintain.

Quick Reference



Ask yourself: "Does this component have one cohesive responsibility and one primary reason to change?"

That question is the heart of SRP.